Nair had expected that with elections around the corner, the political leadership would pressure the management to come to terms with the agitating labour. The prospects of the goodwill and potential votes any favourable settlement would generate among the workers and their families would, he hoped, persuade the political leaders into weighing in on his side. It proved to be a miscalculation. He did get the support of a few political leaders opposed to the Congress, like Datta Samant, George Fernandes and Madhu Dandavate. But this may have ironically gone against Nair and his team. As a Congress chief minister, Pawar had to act. He could not be seen idly standing by as the opposition gained politically from the labour strife. The die was cast, and the chief minister ordered action.

At 2.30 a.m. on 30 September, the state reserve police and the Pune city police launched Operation Crackdown. They turned up with more than seventy-one buses and in about eight and a half hours, an estimated 4,000 striking workers were removed.

The workers were taken to different locations in Pune. Nair and his core team were charged with attempt to commit suicide and violating prohibitory orders, and taken to Ratnagiri jail. Nair was, however, released on bail after a few days.

With the police intervention, the backbone of the strike was broken. Ratan had won the grim battle, the first and last fight he would wage against trade unions. But in triumph, he chose to be graceful and not combative or overbearing. In a clear attempt to look reconciliatory and shorn of rancour, he reached out to all the company employees to win their hearts and souls.

Within a fortnight of the crackdown, he wrote a letter, both cautionary and placatory, to the supervisory staff. Dated 11 October, the letter said that it took ‘considerable strength and courage to stand up to what one believes is right, and not to cave in under pressure’. Its underlying meaning was not in doubt—under his leadership, the Tatas would not bend, irrespective of the odds they faced, to defend what they believed was right, and they would not yield to ransom. He also thanked the employees for their support and said: ‘Your support and dedication has been a very important ingredient in enabling Telco to uphold its position vis-à-vis the present crisis, and it makes me particularly proud to know that we have people like you—with great courage and determination—as members of the Telco team.’

He also did not forget to thank their families: ‘I would also like to express my thanks to members of your family for their own courage during